

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 20

**TEMPLE
ARCHITECTURE**

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE



Shore temple at Mahabalipuram

1 Just as the Nagara school of architecture with the different sub-schools emerged in the northern part of India, a distinct style of temple architecture merged in peninsular India as well.

2 Temple architecture in South India began under the **Pallava ruler Mahendravarman**.

3 The temples developed during the **Pallava Dynasty** reflected the stylistic taste of the individual rulers and can be classified into four stages chronologically.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

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SOUTH INDIAN STYLE

MAHENDRA GROUP

1ST STAGE



Rock-cut temples of Mahendravarman

1

This was the first stage of Pallava temple architecture.

2

The temples built under Mahendravarman were basically rock-cut temples.

3

Under him, the temples were known as Mandapas, unlike the Nagara style in which the Mandapas meant only the Assembly hall.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE

NARASIMHA GROUP

2ND STAGE



Dharmaraja ratha

1

This represented the second stage of the development of temple architecture in South India.

2

Narasimhavarman I, also known as Mamalla, who acceded the Pallava throne around 640 CE, is celebrated for the expansion of the empire, avenging the defeat his father had suffered at the hands of Pulakesin II.

3

He inaugurated most of the building works at Mahabalipuram which is known after him as Mamallapuram.

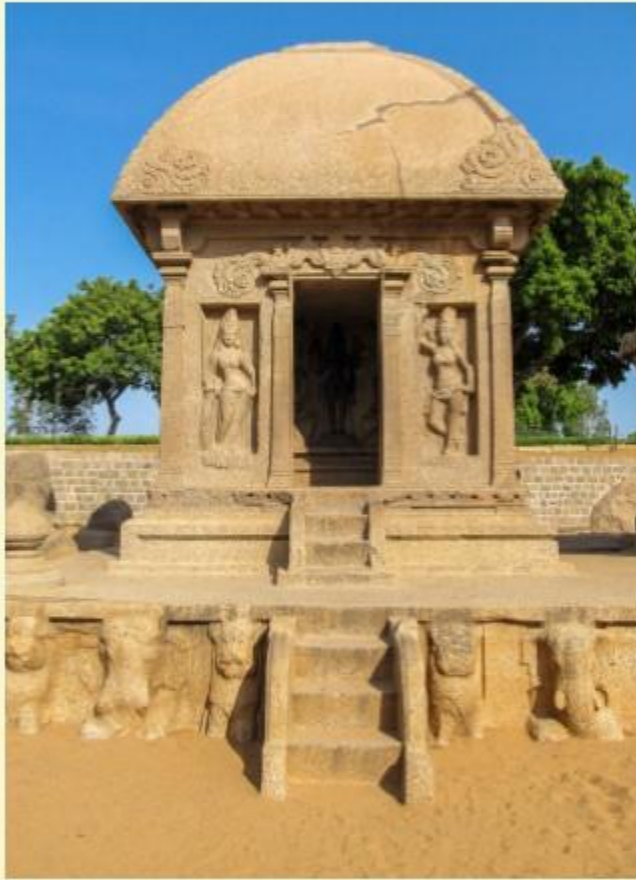
TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE

NARASIMHA GROUP

2ND STAGE



Draupadi ratha

- 4 Under Narasimhavarman, the mandapas were now divided into separate rathas.
- 5 The rock-cut temples were decorated by intricate sculptures.
- 6 The biggest one was called the Dharmaraja ratha while the smallest one was called the Draupadi ratha.
- 7 The design of a temple in the Dravidian style of architecture is a successor of the Dharmaraja ratha.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

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SOUTH INDIAN STYLE

RAJSIMHA GROUP

3RD STAGE



Shore temple at Mahabalipuram

1 The Shore temple at Mahabalipuram was built later, probably in the reign of Narasimhavarman II, also known as Rajasimha who reigned from 700 to 728 CE.

2 Rajsimhavarman led the third stage of temple development. Under him, development of real structural temples was started in the place of rock-cut temples.

3 Example: Shore temple at Mahabalipuram, Kailashnath Temple at Kanchipuram etc.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

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SOUTH INDIAN STYLE

NANDIVARMAN GROUP

4TH STAGE

1 This was the fourth stage of temple development during the Pallava dynasty.

2 The temples built under him were smaller in size.

3 The features were almost similar to the Dravidian style of temple architecture.

4 After the decline of Pallava dynasty, temple architecture acquired a new style under the Chola Kingdom, known as the Dravidian style of temple architecture.

5 This marked a new era in the development of temples in the Southern India.

In the later periods, three other styles Vesara style, Nayaka style and Vijayanagar style also emerged in this region.

CHOLA ARCHITECTURE



CHOLA ART

GS PAPER 1 QUESTION

PREVIOUS YEARS MAINS QUESTION

1

Chola architecture represents a high watermark in the evolution of temple architecture. Discuss. (2013)

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

DRAVIDIAN STYLE

CHOLA ART

Under the Patronage of the Chola rulers, hundreds of temple were built in South India. It was a continuation of the previous Pallava architecture, with some variations. This is what came to be known as the Dravidian style of temple architecture. The features of the Dravidian Style or Chola style are:



1 Unlike the Nagara Temples, the Dravidian temples were surrounded by high boundary walls.

2 The front wall had a high entrance gateway known as the gopuram.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

DRAVIDIAN STYLE

CHOLA ART



3

The temple premise was laid out in the **Panchayatan style** with a principal temple and four subsidiary shrines.

4

In the Dravidian style, the spire is in the form of a **stepped pyramid** that rises up linearly rather than curved. It is known as **Vimana**.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

DRAVIDIAN STYLE

CHOLA ART



Dwarapalas

5

The assembly hall was connected with the garbhagriha by a vestibular tunnel known as Antarala.

6

The entrance of the Garbhagriha had sculptures of Dwaarpal, mithunas and Yakshas.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

DRAVIDIAN STYLE

CHOLA ART



Gangaikonda Cholapuram

7

The presence of a water tank inside the temple enclosure was a unique feature of the Dravidian style.

8

The best examples of Chola architecture are **Brihadeswara Temple at Tanjore** (built by Raja Raja I in 1011 A.D.) and **Gangai kondacholapuram temple** (built by Rajendra I to commemorate his victory in the Gangetic delta), etc.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

DRAVIDIAN STYLE

CHOLA SCULPTURE



Ravan Phadi caves at Aihole

- 1 An important feature of the Chola temples was the importance placed on the decoration through sculpture.
- 2 An important piece of Chola sculpture was the sculpture of Nataraja, the Tandava Dance Posture.
- 3 Though the earliest known Nataraja sculpture, which has been excavated at Ravan Phadi cave at Aihole, was made during the early Chalukya rule, the sculpture reached its peak under the Cholas.

CHOLA ART

GS PAPER 1 QUESTION

PREVIOUS YEARS MAINS QUESTION

2 Discuss the Tandava dance as recorded in the early Indian inscriptions. (2013)

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

DRAVIDIAN STYLE

FEATURES OF NATARAJA SCULPTURE

Eternal
Fire

Damru

Abhaya
Mudra



1 The **upper right hand** holds the drum, which signifies the sound of creation. All creations spring from the great sound of the **Damru**.

2 The **upper left hand** holds the **eternal fire**, which represents the destruction. Destruction is the precursor and inevitable counterpart of creation.

3 The **lower right hand** is raised in the gesture of **Abhay Mudra** signifying benediction and reassuring the devotee to not be afraid.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

DRAVIDIAN STYLE

FEATURES OF NATARAJA SCULPTURE

Flow of
Ganges

Points
towards
upraised foot

dwarf



4 The lower left hand points towards the upraised foot and indicates the path of salvation.

5 Shiva is dancing on the figure of a small dwarf. The dwarf symbolizes ignorance and the ego of an individual.

6 The matted and flowing locks of Shiva represent the flow of river Ganges.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

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DRAVIDIAN STYLE

FEATURES OF NATARAJA SCULPTURE



Glowing
lights

Snake

7

In ornamentation, one ear of Shiva has a male earring while the other has female. This represents the fusion of male and female and is often referred to as **Ardhanarishwar**.

8

A snake is twisted around the arm of Shiva. The **snake symbolizes the Kundalini** power, which resides in the human spine in dormant stage. If aroused, one can attain true consciousness.

9

The Nataraja is **surrounded by a nimbus of glowing lights** which symbolizes the vast unending cycles of time.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

3

NAYAKA STYLE

- 1 The Nayaka school of architecture flourished under the Nayaka rulers in the period between 16th centuries and 18th centuries A.D. It was also known as **Madurai school**.



- 2 It was **architecturally similar to the Dravidian style**, but much larger in scope.

- 3 Some of the unique features are:
 - Presence of **Prakarns or huge corridors** in the portico, around the garbhagriha, along with **roofed ambulatory passageways**.
 - The gopurams built under the Nayaka rulers were some of the largest gopurams. The **art of gopuram reached its climax in the Nayaka style**.
 - The temple structure was filled with intricate carvings.
 - **Example:** Meenakshi temple, Madurai.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

4

VESARA STYLE



Dodda Basappa temple

- 1 Also known as the **Karnataka school of architecture**, it flourished under the **later Chalukya rulers** in the mid-seventh century A.D.
- 2 It combined features of both Nagara school and Dravidian school and resulted in a **hybridised style**.
- 3 Some of its features are:
 - Emphasis on vimana and mandapa
 - Open ambulatory passageway
 - The pillars, doorways and the ceilings were decorated with intricate carvings.
 - **Example:** Dodda Basappa temple at Dambal, Ladkhan temple at Aihole, temples at Badami, etc.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

5

VIJAYANAGAR STYLE



Lotus Mahal, Hampi

- 1 The rulers of the Vijaynagar empire were great patrons of art and architecture.
- 2 Under them, the architectural style started to be influenced by the **Indo-Islamic style of Bijapur** which, in turn, was reflected in the temples built during this period.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

5

VIJAYANAGAR STYLE



Vittalaswami temple, Hampi

3

The features of the temples were:

- The walls of the temples were highly decorated with carvings and geometrical patterns.
- Gopurams, which were previously present on the front side, were now built on all the sides.
- The enclosing walls were larger.
- More than one mandapas were built in each temple. The central mandapa came to be known as kalyan mandap.
- The concept of secular buildings inside the temple premises was also introduced during this period.
- **Example:** Vittalaswami temple, Lotus Mahal etc.

6

HOYSALA STYLE



1 In the region of Karnataka near Mysore, the temples built under the Hoysala rulers developed a distinct style of their own known as the Hoysala School of art.

2 It developed in the period from 1050-1300 A.D with the prominent seats being Belur, Halebid and Sringeri.



Chennakesava temple

3

Some of the features of the architecture are:

- Multiple shrines were built around a central pillared hall.
- *Unlike the crucified ground plan of the Panchayatan style, the shrines led out in the shape of an intricately designed star. This was known as the Stellate plan.*
- Soft soap stone was the main building material.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

6

HOYSALA STYLE



Chennakesava temple

3

Some of the features of the architecture are (continued...):

- **Massive emphasis was laid on the decoration** of the temple through sculptures. Both the interior and exterior walls, even the jewellery worn by the deities were intricately carved.
- **All the chambers had Shikharas** which were interconnected by an arrangement of horizontal lines and mouldings. This **resolved the tower into an orderly succession of tiers**.
- The temples were built on an upraised platform known as **Jagati, which was about 1 metre high**.
- The walls and stairs of the temple followed a zigzag pattern.

Example: Hoyasaleshwara temple at Halebid,
Chennakesava temple at Belur.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

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PALA STYLE



- 1 In Bengal region, the style of architecture came to be known as **Pala school of architecture**.
- 2 It developed in the period between 8th and 12th century A.D. under the **patronage of Pala dynasty and Sena dynasty**.
- 3 The Palas were mainly Buddhist rulers, while the Senas were Hindus.
- 4 Thus, the architecture reflected the influence of both the religions.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

7

PALA STYLE



Bangla roof

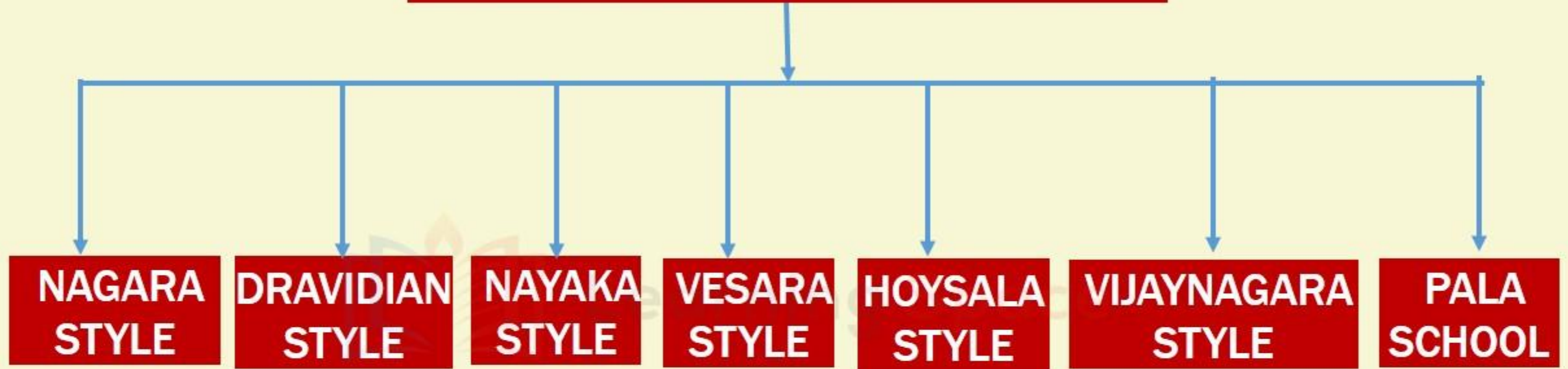
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The architecture of this region is featured by:

- The building has a curve or sloping roof, as in bamboo huts. This became popularly known as “Bangla roof” and was later adopted by the Mughal architects.
- Burnt bricks and clay, known as terracotta bricks, was the principal building material used.
- The temples of this region had a tall, curving shikhara crowned by a large amalaka, similar to the Odisha school.
- For the sculptures of this region, both stone as well as metal was used. Stone was the major component.
- The figures were unique in their highly lustrous finish.

Example: Siddhesvara Mahadeva temple in Barakar, temples around Vishnupur, etc.

STYLE OF TEMPLE ARCHITECTURES



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